

Green Keel-Bellied Lizard Care Guide

Gastropholis prasina

Green keel-bellied lizards are 10-14 in long, diurnal, arboreal lizards native to Kenya and Tanzania. They are active climbers that spend much of their time above ground. They have slender bodies, a tapered snout, large eyes, long toes, and prominent rectangular scales, with coloration ranging from vivid green to turquoise.

They are best suited to intermediate keepers. Maximum lifespan is not well established.

Enclosure Size

The absolute minimum enclosure size for one adult is about 36 x 18 x 36 in. Larger is strongly preferred because this species makes extensive use of vertical space.

Multiple animals are not required for wellbeing. Groups may sometimes coexist, but sex, breeding plans, enclosure size, visual barriers, and individual behavior must all be considered carefully.

UVB and Lighting

Green keel-bellied lizards should receive UVB lighting. Appropriate examples include Arcadia T5 HO 6% or Zoo Med T5 HO ReptiSun 5.0 at about 6-8 in above the basking branch, or Arcadia T5 HO 12% / Zoo Med T5 HO ReptiSun 10.0 at about 12-14 in. Use a quality reflector fixture and follow current manufacturer positioning guidance.

Because these lizards may climb near the enclosure ceiling, prevent access that would expose them to excessive UV. UVB is blocked by ordinary glass and plastic, so sunlight through a window is not a substitute. Replace UVB lamps according to manufacturer guidance, commonly around every 12 months for T5 HO systems.

A bright 6500 K LED or fluorescent grow light can improve daytime illumination and support live plants. A 12-hour day/night cycle is a practical baseline.

Temperature

Provide a basking area around 90 F, measured at the basking branch with a reliable probe thermometer. General ambient temperatures should remain around 70-80 F, with nighttime temperatures able to fall to roughly 65 F.

A cluster of halogen basking bulbs can provide broad radiant heat. Turn daytime heat sources off at night unless room temperatures fall below the safe nighttime range.

Humidity

Maintain average humidity around 60-80% while providing good airflow. Measure humidity with a digital hygrometer near the middle of the enclosure. Misting once or twice daily, often morning and evening, can help maintain humidity and provide drinking droplets.

Substrate

Use a naturalistic moisture-retentive substrate such as coco fiber, ReptiSoil, plantation-style soil, or a jungle-style reptile substrate. A layer of clean, chemical-free leaf litter can help retain humidity and provide cover. Use at least about 2 in of substrate, spot-clean waste daily, and replace substrate as needed, commonly every 3-4 months.

Decor and Enrichment

Provide substantial vertical structure. At minimum include secure climbing branches, a basking branch, and dense live or artificial foliage. Additional useful features include cork hollows, vines, elevated ledges, live or artificial plants, and textured climbable surfaces.

Feeding

Green keel-bellied lizards are primarily insectivorous. Juveniles may be fed daily, while adults can often be fed 2-3 times per week. Rotate feeder species for nutritional variety.

Suitable feeders include dubia or discoid roaches, crickets, hornworms, silkworms, mealworms, darkling beetles, grasshoppers, and black soldier fly larvae. Complete crested gecko diet may be offered occasionally as a treat rather than as the dietary staple.

Supplements

Use a balanced calcium and vitamin supplementation routine appropriate for the animal's UVB exposure and feeder variety. A low-D3 all-in-one supplement can be used lightly on feeder insects when appropriate.

Water

Provide a small clean water bowl in addition to misting. Change the water daily and clean the bowl regularly with a reptile-safe disinfectant.

Handling

Green keel-bellied lizards are fast, alert, and often better suited to observation than routine handling. Calm tong or tweezer feeding is generally less stressful than frequent restraint.

This guide is a general husbandry reference. Continue researching current high-quality sources, observe the individual animal closely, and consult a reptile-experienced veterinarian when health concerns arise.